PROJECT WORTH

GROOMING AWARENESS FOR BYSTANDERS

YOU HAVE THE POWER TO SPEAK AND ACT

Grooming happens when an adult has a sexual agenda involving a child and misuses the child's trust, vulnerability, age, or need for connection to fulfill it. It is a deliberate pattern of building trust, crossing boundaries, creating secrecy, and gaining control before exploitation or abuse.

It may look like attention, support, mentoring, affection, gifts, spiritual guidance, opportunities, or protection. It may not feel dangerous at first. That is the point.

Grooming can begin before a child reaches the legal age of consent

Reaching that age later does not erase concerns about earlier manipulation, secrecy, dependency, exploitation, or misuse of power.

Children often do not understand they are being groomed or abused, especially while it is happening. That is why bystanders matter.

KNOW THE SIGNS

Pay attention when an adult:

- Seeks unusual access to a child
- Creates secrecy or private communication
- Gives excessive attention, gifts, or opportunities
- Ignores boundaries
- Protects their reputation over the child's safety

People who groom children may appear charismatic, helpful, well liked, or respected in the community. Status or reputation is never above accountability.

INTENTIONAL FALSE REPORTS ARE UNCOMMON

Intentionally false allegations of child sexual abuse appear to be uncommon. Disclosure can carry significant emotional, social, and practical costs for survivors.

Delayed disclosure is common. Many minimize what happened, disclose gradually, or never disclose at all.

Take concerns seriously. Listen calmly. Report - don't investigate.

BE A SAFE ADULT

- Take disclosures seriously
- Listen without blaming or defending the adult
- Help the child connect with safe people and support
- Document concerns
- Report suspected abuse; escalate grooming or boundary concerns
- Choose child safety over comfort, image, or reputation

NOTICE. SPEAK UP. HELP KEEP CHILDREN SAFE.

A child may not have the words, confidence, freedom, or understanding to explain what is happening. You may be the person who notices, believes them, interrupts access, and helps them get connected.

THE DAMAGE OF SILENCE

Ignoring credible warning signs can leave children unprotected and allow concerning behavior to continue.

When adults fail to speak or act, children may feel invisible, unprotected, or responsible. Silence can deepen the harm and place others at risk.

> *The trauma itself impacted me horribly. But a deeper wound came from authorities who failed to take appropriate action to stop this.*
>
> Kerri, at a press conference supporting Wisconsin Senate Bill 333, now Wisconsin Act 200

COURAGE LOOKS LIKE ACTION

Pay attention | Believe them | Document concerns | Report and stay connected

Protecting children is everyone's responsibility.

SUPPORT

RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline

800 656 HOPE (4673)

Text HOPE to 64673

rainn.org

For mental health crisis support, call or text 988.

Together, we light up the darkness.

Believe kids. Believe survivors. Choose child safety. Connect with us at Project Worth.

projectworthwi.org | info@projectworthwi.org